

PUBPOL 303

Policy Choice as Value Conflict

Session 2, Fall 2025



Dates: October 20 – December 4

Course meeting time: Monday/Wednesday 8:30-11:00am BJT

Academic credit: 4 Credits

Course format: Seminar discussion.

Weekly office hours: Monday and Tuesday 1:30pm – 3:30pm BJT, in AB 2112

*****Note***:** This syllabus is subject to change at any time at my discretion. When I make changes, I will upload a new version of the syllabus on Canvas and send a notice that I have done so. Make sure you are always working from the most recent version.

Instructor's Information

Name: Dylan Munson

PhD Candidate in Environmental Policy, Duke University

Email: dylan.munson@duke.edu

I study climate change adaptation, especially as it pertains to smallholder farming in the Nile Basin of Eastern Africa. My work tends to use computational techniques, such as network analysis and simulation modeling. It combines insights from the natural and social sciences to better understand how governments can design policies that maximize the ability of farmers to withstand the shocks to their livelihood which come with climate change. Outside of work, I enjoy traveling (and am excited to see more of China while I am here), as well as reading, hiking, and watching movies. I received my Bachelor of Arts from McGill University in 2020, with majors in economics and English literature.

What is this course about?

Policy choices emerge from, respond to, and attempt to manage or mitigate value conflicts. In this course, we explore the meaning of this proposition; the various responsibilities that policymakers should assume in light of it; and a variety of ethical frameworks that scholars and policymakers deploy in reasoning about decisionmakers' responsibilities. The aim is to develop students' ability to assess how (well) policymakers are confronting some of the most pressing public problems of the day – and to enhance students' own capacity to confront them as well.

Throughout, special attention will go to questions of justice, freedom, democracy, and rights; how these concepts are variously understood; and the trade-offs and dilemmas involved in trying to realize the values associated with them. Readings will be drawn from political theory and philosophy but also interdisciplinary policy studies, with contributions from economics, political science, and beyond.

What background knowledge do I need before taking this course?

PUBPOL 101 is a prerequisite for this course. Otherwise, no substantive background knowledge will be presupposed.

I do, however, recommend that students wait until *at least their second year* to take this course.

What will I learn in this course?

By the end of this course, you should be able to:

1. **Identify** diverse sources of value conflict in public policymaking.
2. **Verbally communicate** diverse ethical frameworks for understanding and responding to value conflict in policymaking.
3. **Assess and convey** to others some of the merits of these ethical frameworks, as well as their problems, liabilities, shortcomings, etc.
4. **Effectively and concisely describe** some of the ethical trade-offs and dilemmas that policymakers and citizens face in the contemporary world, and how (well) they deal with them in various policy areas.

What will I do in this course?

1. Complete the **required readings** for the course.
2. Participate in **seminar discussions and other in-class activities**.
3. Complete **Canvas discussion posts for one class a week** (after the first class).
4. Complete **five short in-class quizzes** throughout the semester.
5. Complete **two oral exams** (midterm and final) with me in my office.

How can I prepare for the class sessions to be successful?

To accomplish the course's learning objectives, you will need to do five main things:

- (1) **Thoroughly read the required readings prior to each class meeting.** Interact with the readings: take notes, underline key concepts, write in the margins, imagine you are in dialogue with the author, etc. There are many techniques; do what works best for you. The most important thing is to read and respond *actively*!
- (2) **Bring your copies of the day's readings to class.**
- (3) **Come to each class ready and eager to learn, with an open mind.** Criticism and self-criticism are welcome – indeed, highly encouraged. To really learn from others – from fellow students, instructors and authors alike – you have to be willing to read and listen *charitably*; you have to adopt others' perspectives, even if temporarily, and try to understand how they see the matter in question. You don't have to agree with them. But you do have to try respectfully to understand why others think and feel as they do.

(4) **Complete all of the assignments diligently, enthusiastically, and imaginatively.**

What required texts, materials, and equipment will I need?

Please see the list of assigned readings under “**What is the expected course schedule?**” All readings are available through Canvas (under the “Resources” tab).

What optional texts or resources might be helpful?

There are many additional sources I might recommend, depending on which topics interest you most. Feel free to speak with me during office hours about further recommendations.

How will my grade be determined?

- **Engagement (two components): 25%**
 - Students should engage asynchronously and synchronously, as detailed below.
 - **Component 1 (Asynchronous): Weekly Canvas discussion posts, submitted prior to each Monday class meeting (10%)**
 - i) The first posts will be due prior to the Monday of the second week of class and will then continue until the end of the session.
 - ii) Students should post a brief question for discussion or comment on the required readings (i.e., you should **start your own discussion thread/conversation**).
 - iii) Students should **briefly respond to at least one of the questions posed or comments made by other students**.
 - iv) Each post should be at least two full sentences.
 - v) Your own discussion thread (your initial post) should be done by **4:00 pm the Sunday before class**. The additional posts should be done by **8:00 pm the Sunday before class**.
 - (1) Graded on a Full Credit/Half Credit/No Credit basis
 - (a) Full credit: the above instructions are *fully* followed
 - (b) Half credit: the above instructions are *partly* followed (including at least one post by 8:00 pm the day before class)
 - (c) No credit is given when there are no posts by 8:00 pm the day before class (or no posts at all).
 - **Component 2 (Synchronous): Live Engagement (15%)**
 - i) Active engagement in classroom activities
 - ii) Participation in assigned group activities outside of the regularly scheduled class meetings (e.g., peer review exercises)
- **In-class quizzes (20%)**
 - During the last half hour of the Wednesday class **during weeks 2, 3, 5, 6, and 7**, a brief review quiz will be held to test your understanding of the concepts discussed in the readings and in-class discussions. Thus, doing the readings and actively participating in class discussions is the best way to perform well on these quizzes.
 - The quizzes will generally **not** require rote memorization of facts/statistics from the readings, but will be on general concepts, terms, and situations.
 - The quizzes are cumulative in the sense that knowledge of **all** readings and discussions up to that point may be required, but they will focus on readings and discussions from the week in question.

- The quiz on which each student scores the lowest out of the five will be dropped from their gradebook.
- **Midterm oral exam (25%)**
 - Will occur Monday of week 4
- **Final oral exam (30%)**
 - Will be scheduled during exam week

Please refer to the following scale for your grading.

A+= 98% - 100% **A** = 97% - 93%; **A-** = 90% - 92%; **B+** = 87% - 89%; **B** = 83% - 86%; **B-** = 80% - 82%; **C+** = 77% - 79%; **C** = 73% - 76%; **C-** = 70% - 72%; **D+** = 67% - 69%; **D** = 63% - 66%; **D-** = 60% - 62% **F** = 59% and below

What are the course policies?

Communications:

Students should check their email daily for any updates regarding the course, the readings, assignments, and so forth. Announcements will be made through the Canvas course site for this class; such announcements will automatically be forwarded to your DKU email address.

Discussion Guidelines:

Civility is essential to academic life. All communications for this course should be conducted constructively, civilly, and respectfully. Differences in beliefs, opinions, and approaches are to be expected. Please bring any communications you believe to be in violation of this class policy to the attention of the instructor. Active interaction with peers and the instructor is essential to success in this course. Please pay particular attention to the following guidelines:

- Be respectful of others and their opinions, valuing diversity in backgrounds, abilities, and experiences.
- Challenging the ideas held by others is an integral aspect of critical thinking and academic life. Please word your responses carefully and recognize that others are expected to challenge your ideas. A positive atmosphere of healthy discussion and debate is encouraged.
- Read your online discussion posts carefully before submitting them.

Academic Integrity:

As a student, you should abide by the academic honesty standard of Duke Kunshan University. Its Community Standard states: “Duke Kunshan University is a community comprised of individuals from diverse cultures and backgrounds. We are dedicated to scholarship, leadership, and service and to the principles of honesty, fairness, respect, and accountability. Members of this community commit to reflecting upon and upholding these principles in all academic and non-academic endeavors, and to protecting and promoting a culture of integrity and trust.”

Please see the addendum at the end of this document for the policy on Artificial Intelligence (AI) in this course. To briefly summarize: AI-based tools are prohibited.

Academic Policy & Procedures:

You are responsible for knowing and adhering to academic policy and procedures as published in the University Bulletin and the Student Handbook. Please note: an incident of behavioral infraction or academic dishonesty (cheating on an assignment, plagiarizing, etc.) will result in immediate action from me (**including the possibility of a zero on the assignment**), in consultation with university administration (e.g., Dean of Undergraduate Studies, Associate Dean of Undergraduate Studies, Student Conduct, Academic Advising). Please visit the Undergraduate Studies website for [additional guidance related to academic policy and procedures](#), especially concerning academic integrity.

Academic integrity is everyone's responsibility. If you are unsure about whether some action constitutes unacceptable behavior or plagiarism, please ask me.

Disruptive Behavior and Community Standards:

Please avoid all forms of disruptive behavior, including but not limited to verbal or physical threats, repeated obscenities, and unreasonable interference with class discussion.

No class sessions may be recorded by a student without instructor permission.

If you choose not to adhere to these standards, I will take action in consultation with university administration (e.g., Dean of Undergraduate Studies, Student Conduct, Academic Advising).

Depending on the classroom activity at any given time, students may be asked **to use or not use** their computers and/or other electronic devices (e.g., tablets). Students who are caught browsing social media or other non-course related sites during class time may be marked as absent, **adversely affecting your engagement grade**. I take this particularly seriously because such browsing distracts not only you but also your classmates.

Academic Accommodations:

If you need to request accommodation for a disability, you need a signed accommodation plan from Campus Health Services, and you need to provide a copy of that plan to me. Visit the Office of Student Affairs website for additional information and instruction related to accommodations.

What campus resources can help me during this course?

Academic Advising and Student Support

Please consult with me about appropriate course preparation and readiness strategies, as needed. Consult your academic advisors on course performance (i.e., poor grades) and academic decisions (e.g., course changes, incompletes, withdrawals) to ensure you stay on track with degree and graduation requirements. In addition to advisors, staff in the Academic Resource Center (ARC) can provide recommendations on academic success strategies (e.g., tutoring, coaching, student learning preferences). All ARC services will continue to be provided online. Note: there is an ARC Canvas site

for students and tutors. Please visit the Office of Undergraduate Advising website for additional information related to academic advising and student support services.

Writing and Language Studio

If you want additional help with academic writing and with language learning more generally, you are welcome to go to the [Writing and Language Studio \(WLS\)](#). You can register for an account, make an appointment, and learn more about WLS services, policies, and events on the [WLS website](#). You can also find writing and language learning resources on the [Writing & Language Studio Canvas site](#).

IT Support

If you are experiencing technical difficulties, please contact IT:

- Phone: 0512-3665-7100
- Live Chat: <https://oit.duke.edu/help>
- Email: service-desk@dukekunshan.edu.cn

What is the expected course schedule?

Week 1, Session 1

Date	Monday, October 20
Class topic	Illustrating the Plurality of Ethical Frameworks: Environmental Ethics and Policymaking
Pre-class work for students	Marion Hourdequin, “Bringing Values to Light,” chapter 1 in <i>Environmental Ethics: From Theory to Practice</i> (Bloomsbury, 2015). Read 3-20 only.
Planned in-class activities	Brief discussion of syllabus, class policies, course plan, and assigned readings.
Assignments due	Read the syllabus in full

Week 1, Session 2

Date	Wednesday, October 22
Class topic	Illustrating the Plurality of Ethical Frameworks: Environmental Ethics and Policymaking

Pre-class work for students	Marion Hourdequin, “Classical Ethical Theories and the Environment,” chapter 2 in <i>Environmental Ethics: From Theory to Practice</i> (Bloomsbury, 2015), 29-56. Hourdequin, “Anthropocentrism and Its Critics: Broadening Moral Concern,” chapter 3 in <i>Environmental Ethics</i>. Read only 57-67, 80-84.
Planned in-class activities	Seminar discussion on the assigned readings.
Assignments due	None

Week 2, Session 1

Date	Monday, October 27
Class topic	How Far Should Rights Extend? Alternative Ways of Valuing Animal Life
Pre-class work for students	Read excerpts from Arthur Caplan and Robert Arp, editors, <i>Contemporary Debates in Bioethics</i> (Wiley and Sons, 2014): The editors’ introduction to part 9, “Should We Prohibit the Use of Chimpanzees and Other Great Apes in Biomedical Research?”, 261-68. Chapter 17 by Jean Kazez, “We Should Prohibit the Use of Chimpanzees and Other Great Apes in Biomedical Research,” 271-79. Chapter 18 by Carl Cohen, “We Should Not Prohibit the Use of Chimpanzees and Other Great Apes in Biomedical Research,” 281-89. “Reply to Cohen,” by Jean Kazez, 291-93. “Reply to Kazez,” by Carl Cohen, 294-96.
Planned in-class activities	Seminar discussion on the assigned readings
Assignments due	Canvas discussion posts

Week 2, Session 2

Date	Wednesday, October 29
Class topic	How Should We “Value” Nature in Policymaking? Instrumental, Intrinsic, and Relational Valuations and Discounting
Pre-class work for students	An excerpt from William Baxter, “The Case for Optimal Pollution,” in <i>Penguins or People: The Case for Optimal Pollution</i> (Columbia University Press, 1974). [4 pages] George Monbiot, “The UK Wants to Put a Price on Nature – But That Will Destroy It,” in <i>The Guardian</i>, 15 May 2018. [about 2 pages] “Chapter 2: Economics, ethics, and climate change” in <i>The Stern Review Report on the Economics of Climate Change</i> (2006) [you don’t have to worry about the parts requiring microeconomics!] Kai Chan et al., “Why Protect Nature? Rethinking Values and the Environment,” <i>Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences</i> 113, 6 (2016): 1462-65.
Planned in-class activities	Seminar discussion on the assigned readings Quiz 1
Assignments due	None

Week 3, Session 1

Date	Monday, November 3
Class topic	What Values Should Guide Immigration? “Open” versus “Closed” Borders
Pre-class work for students	Joseph Carens, “The Case for Open Borders,” chapter 11 in <i>The Ethics of Immigration</i> (Oxford University Press, 2013), 225-254.
Planned in-class activities	Seminar discussion on the assigned readings
Assignments	Canvas discussion posts

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Week 3, Session 2

Date	Wednesday, November 5
Class topic	What Values Should Guide Immigration? “Open” versus “Closed” Borders
Pre-class work for students	Michael Walzer, “Membership,” chapter 2 in <i>Spheres of Justice: A Defense of Pluralism and Equality</i> (Basic Books, 1983), 31-63. --Note: You may skip the section “The Athenian Metics,” 53-55.
Planned in-class activities	Seminar discussion on the assigned readings Quiz 2
Assignments due	None

*****Midterm oral exams will occur during Week 4. Dates and times to be announced.**

No office hours Week 4 due to the oral exams.

No Canvas posts or quiz during Week 4.

Week 4, Session 1

Date	Monday, November 10
Class topic	Oral exams
Pre-class work for students	Not applicable
Planned in-class activities	Not applicable

Assignments due	Not applicable
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Week 4, Session 2

Date	Wednesday, November 12
Class topic	What Values Should Guide Poverty Reduction? Targeting versus Universalism
Pre-class work for students	Stephen Devereux, “Is Targeting Ethical?”, <i>Global Social Policy</i> 16, 2 (2016): 166-179. Xuan Huo and Mingang Lin, “Understanding Welfare Stigma in China,” <i>China: An International Journal</i> 17, 1 (2019): 29-47.
Planned in-class activities	Seminar discussion on the assigned readings
Assignments due	None

Week 5, Session 1

Date	Monday, November 17
Class topic	What Values Should Guide Poverty Reduction? Targeting versus Universalism
Pre-class work for students	Phillipe Van Parijs and Yannick Vanderborght, “The Instrument of Freedom,” chapter 1 in <i>Basic Income: A Radical Proposal for a Free Society and a Sane Economy</i> (Harvard University Press, 2017), 4-28. Tera Allas et al., “ An Experiment to Inform Universal Basic Income ,” <i>McKinsley and Company</i> , September 2020. [6 pages]
Planned in-class activities	Seminar discussion on the assigned readings
Assignments due	Canvas discussion posts

Week 5, Session 2

Date	Wednesday, November 19
Class topic	How Might We Overcome Historical, Group-Based Injustice? The Ethics and Effectiveness of Affirmative Action
Pre-class work for students	Elizabeth Anderson, “The Imperative of Integration,” chapter 6 in <i>The Imperative of Integration</i> (Princeton University Press, 2010), 112-34.
Planned in-class activities	Seminar discussion on the assigned readings Quiz 3
Assignments due	None

Week 6, Session 1

Date	Monday, November 24
Class topic	How Might We Overcome Historical, Group-Based Injustice? The Ethics and Effectiveness of Affirmative Action
Pre-class work for students	Elizabeth Anderson, “Understanding Affirmative Action,” chapter 7 in <i>The Imperative of Integration</i> (Princeton University Press, 2010), 135-154.
Planned in-class activities	Seminar discussion on the required readings
Assignments due	Canvas discussion posts

Week 6, Session 2

Date	Wednesday, November 26
Class topic	How Might We Overcome Historical, Group-Based Injustice? The Ethics and Effectiveness of Affirmative Action

Pre-class work for students	Thomas Sowell, “Affirmative Action in India,” <i>Affirmative Action around the World: An Empirical Study</i> (Yale University Press, 2004), 23-54.
Planned in-class activities	Seminar discussion on the assigned readings Quiz 4
Assignments due	None

Week 7, Session 1

Date	Monday, December 1
Class topic	Contesting Rulership: Who Should Our Rulers Be? What Should They Be Like? How Should They Be Selected?
Pre-class work for students	Tongdong Bai, “A Confucian Version of Hybrid Regime: How Does It Work, and Why Is It Superior?”, chapter 2 in <i>The East Asian Challenge for Democracy: Political Meritocracy in Comparative Perspective</i> , edited by D.A. Bell and Chenyang Li (Cambridge University Press, 2014), 55-82.
Planned in-class activities	Seminar discussion on the assigned readings
Assignments due	Canvas discussion posts

Week 7, Session 2

Date	Wednesday, December 3
Class topic	Contesting Rulership: Who Should Our Rulers Be? What Should They Be Like? How Should They Be Selected?

Pre-class work for students	John Gastil and Erik Olin Wright, "Legislature by Lot: Envisioning Sortition within a Bicameral System," <i>Politics and Society</i> 46, no. 3 (2018): 303-330.
Planned in-class activities	Seminar discussion on the required readings Quiz 5
Assignments due	None

Final oral exams will be scheduled for finals week. Dates and times to be announced.

Addendum: Policy Statement on the Non-Use of AI and Student Communication about Course Assignments

This statement is (a) to clarify the course policy concerning Artificial Intelligence (AI). I would also like (b) to clarify the policy regarding students communicating about assignments and course material outside of class.

(A) The policy on the non-use of Artificial Intelligence in this course.

In this course, students develop their critical thinking and academic skills, including their writing skills (e.g., in preparing their recorded presentation). As such, **the general rule is that artificial intelligence tools should NOT be used for ANY assignment unless I clearly state they can be used.** If you are not sure whether something counts as an "artificial intelligence" tool for our purposes, please ask me.

This course is intended to help you to develop basic and advanced skills that you will employ in many of your courses throughout your time at DKU, and in your life beyond DKU. My goal as your teacher is to help you learn how to generate your own ideas and to communicate them clearly and effectively in your own words. In prohibiting the use of AI tools, I am not thereby suggesting that AI tools are (always) "bad"; instead, it is because I want you to learn for yourself how to effectively communicate your own ideas.

In saying that AI should **NOT** be used in this course (unless I indicate otherwise regarding a specific assignment), I intend to exclude the following potential uses of such technology:

- ***AI-Based Writing:*** Using an AI-based tool to write any part of an assignment and representing that work as your own. It is also prohibited to use an AI-based tool to write any part of an assignment, *even if you credit the tool in a citation.*

- **Text Manipulation:** Taking content written by another person or technology/tool, and using a software program to manipulate/alter it with the intention of misleading plagiarism detection software, or to present it as your own.
- **Non-English Text Translation:** Taking content written in a language other than English (*either* by yourself *or* someone else), running it through a translation tool, and presenting that work as your own. **Note:** you are allowed to use paper or electronic dictionaries to translate individual words or short phrases for reading comprehension and vocabulary improvement.
- **Source misuse or misrepresentation:** Using AI-based tools to generate citations and references without verifying their accuracy, format, or existence.
- **The penalties for academic integrity infringements in this course, including misuse of AI tools, include:**
 - **First Offense:** 0% for the assignment. You *may*, at my discretion, be given the opportunity to rewrite/redo the assignment, with the grade being capped at a "D" (60%). Depending on the severity of the case, you may be referred to the DKU undergraduate academic review board (UARB) for resolution.
 - **Second Offense:** 0% for the assignment. There will be no opportunity to rewrite/redo, and you will be referred to the UARB for resolution.

(B) Student communication about course material and assignments in this course.

You are welcome, indeed encouraged, to talk to fellow students about the readings and the assignments in general. You are free to share your thoughts, reactions, criticisms, and so forth, concerning the texts and in-class discussions. You are free to discuss what you plan to argue, say, or write about in your assignments. Part of what it means to be a university student is that you engage in such conversations; they are central to the university's mission and its intellectual life.

However, for your assignments, **your written and orally presented work in this class must be your own.** Other people, whether fellow students or others (friends, family members, paid consultants, etc.), should NOT review your assignments/written material prior to submission. That is, they should not write or re-write (directly edit) any part of what you submit. (A partial exception to this: I will later ask you to peer review another student's work, and I will give you guidance about what I mean by that at the time).

If you have any questions concerning these policies, please come see me after class or in office hours.